



THE NETHERLANDS BECAME THE FIRST COUNTRY TO SWEEP THE FIELD HOCKEY MEDALS AT THE GAMES SINCE THE WOMEN'S TOURNAMENT WAS ADDED IN 1980

Sustained dominance: The Netherlands narrowly escaped defeat to defend its Olympic title in women's hockey, securing victory over China in a penalty shootout in the final.

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the players. That Upton was by the team's side throughout the Games was an added help.

It is a measure of the team's growth through the competition that, from rank outsiders to even advancing to the last four, the loss to reigning world champion Germany in the semifinal was considered a disaster, a chance squandered. To then come back from it and retain the bronze was impressive. There were, in fact, quite a few things in common with the 1972 outing.

As then captain Ajitpal Singh wrote about the 1972 Munich Olympics in his piece on *Sportstar*, India had a team to win gold but messed up. It missed penalty corners and open chances by the dozen in the semis. It did not have a second

drag-flicker. And it was the beginning of world hockey truly going international, with new teams staking claims. Things that held true in 1972 and in 2024.

But if Paris 2024 threw up surprise results — like Spain defeating Belgium, South Africa pushing the Netherlands hard, or Belgium thrashing Australia — it also stuck to the pre-event form book with the Dutch taking gold.

As the top-ranked side in the competition and with an enviable record — just seven losses in 52 games over the last two years — it was the team to beat, and it remained that, barring a 1-0 blip to Germany in the pool stage. The Dutch women made it a double

delight, the first time ever in Olympic history. Having missed the semifinals for the second straight edition, it also led to questions on whether the famed Australian hockey team needed a hard reset to stay competitive.

Among the women, China's silver was the bright spot, standing out in the usual list of European powerhouses. It was also a measure of how much the presence of good management matters: Alyson Annan, Ric Charlesworth, and Taeke Taekema are names not to be taken lightly, and the result should be a lesson for Hockey India on how a team that it consistently beat till 2022 suddenly turned things around in the last two years.